

changing times and there is no bias. As a result of these measures, Axis bank is one of the top companies in the BT-Taggd Best Companies to Work For in India ranking this year.

“I think the secret sauce for us is the fact that people have been able to settle, assimilate and just adapt; everybody is very, very supportive and helpful,” says Vempati, who has been with the bank for more than seven years. Adapting and assimilating has been smooth and easy even as the bank has continued with its hybrid work culture while encouraging aspects like diversity and inclusion.

For instance, the bank launched its GIG-A Opportunities platform in 2020 to provide alternate work models, and the programme is still in force. Even today, the bank offers a hybrid culture wherein non-customer facing employees have to come to office only twice a week. The bank also has around 4,000 employees working from home on a permanent basis—the bank classifies them as ‘GIG-A Anywhere’.

“We even have GIG-A freelancers who come for fixed-term assignments. Just to give you some context, we put out 50 jobs on a pilot basis in 2020 and we received 66,000 applications in just three weeks. That’s when we realised that things are changing,” says Vempati. “We cannot say we have scarce talent. We’ve got to figure out how we hire people, train them and develop them because [talented] people are there. So, once we put out our GIG-A Anywhere programme, our metrics started improving,” she adds, while highlighting the fact that the overall productivity has gone up. People working remotely even had better ratings in terms of performance and promotion rates in a completely organic manner.



KEY HR INITIATIVES

► **Axis Bank has introduced its GIG-A Opportunities programme for hybrid and remote working**

► **It has come up with a ‘ComeAsYouAre’ charter for the LG-BTQ+ community—**

both for its employees and customers

► **It has a mentoring programme. As part of this, senior managers—including the bank’s MD & CEO—mentor at least nine individuals**

► **Also available is a host of options for upskilling of talent while they are on the job**

► **The lender is pivoting towards internal talent; roles to be necessarily filled up internally**

“If your performance metrics are more output-driven, the organisation will thrive. So we do not bother about where the employee is as long as the outcome is there,” she says.

Then there is the ‘ComeAsYouAre’ charter aimed at the LG-BTQ+ community—both for employees and customers. This allows all employees to list their partners for medical benefits irrespective of gender or marital status, and dress as per their gender or gender expression. Further, customers from the LGBTQ+ community can open a joint account with a same-sex partner or even name them as a nominee, adding their title as ‘Mx’.

Vempati adds that the bank ensures there is proper mentoring across all levels. The bank has also put in a system wherein each

senior manager—including Axis Bank MD & CEO Amitabh Chaudhry—mentors nine employees. Meanwhile, in addition, the bank also offers a host of learning programmes in terms of upskilling employees. For this, it has partnered with US-based online course provider Coursera.

“As an organisation, we all have become very tech-driven. But having conversations in terms of where you are, [and] where you want to be—we need to pay attention to those. Mentoring interactions ignite such conversations. We want the bank to be an organisation that is development-focussed in a very human way,” says Vempati. **BT**

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